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Top Skills

Human Resources
Global Talent Acquisition
Compensation & Benefits

Languages

Portuguese (Native or Bilingual)
French (Professional Working)
English (Full Professional)
Espanhol (Limited Working)

Certifications

Orçamento de Estado 2013 & Novas
Regras de Faturação 2013
Produtividade no Trabalho Remoto:
Como Fazer uma Boa Gestão do
Tempo
ScrumMaster: Características e
Responsabilidades na Gestão de
Projetos
Organização e Gestão da
Segurança
CCP - Certificado Competências
Pedagógicas

Publications

Trabalho Remoto e Experiência do
Trabalhador - Da estratégia à gestão
das pessoas, processos e trabalho

Catarina Ribeiro Simões

Building People Functions from Zero to Scale | Head of People & HR
Director | Strategic & Operational HR | Startups, Scaleups & SaaS
| Scaling Teams 20→300+ | M&A | AI-First HR | Comp & Benefits |
Distributed Teams

Lisbon Metropolitan Area

Summary

I build, restructure, and scale HR departments — from scratch or through transformation. From early-stage startups to large, multinational organizations of 300+ employees, across 20+ locations on 4 continents, in fast-paced, multicultural, remote and distributed environments. 25+ years in global recruitment, compensation and benefits, compliance, downsizing, and team integration in mergers and acquisitions — including the cultural and organizational integration of 12+ companies and 300+ people in a single transformation. I started in Office, Admin, and Finance — a foundation that lets me see People decisions through a sharp business and operational lens, and speak the language of founders, finance, and operations as fluently as that of people. Today, I bring an AI-first approach to people management, leveraging tools like Claude (Anthropic) to automate processes and drive data-informed decisions. I'm also a CCP-certified trainer and co-author of a published handbook on Remote Work and Employee Experience. I believe people do their best work when they feel seen, supported, and challenged — and I work every day to make that happen, regardless of time zone. Industries: SaaS, tech, hospitality, real estate and construction, aviation, and media. Based in Lisbon, working globally — because people management should feel human, even at scale. Open to senior People & HR roles — leadership or strategic — in tech, SaaS and beyond, across high-growth and established organizations, and to new challenges and initiatives that stretch me beyond the familiar. And because growing people is what I do, I'm always glad to support those starting out or navigating a career change. Have an idea for a project, an article, or a book — or a role worth exploring? Let's connect.

Experience

ListKit

Human Resources Director

May 2025 - Present (1 year 3 months)

Sole HR hire for a US-based, AI-driven B2B SaaS platform — building the entire HR function from scratch for a startup in scale-up (ramp-up phase). A fast-paced, highly dynamic environment with a fully distributed, international and multicultural team of nearly 100 people across 20+ locations on 3 continents (US, Europe and Asia).

- Strategic HR leadership — built the entire HR function and people strategy from scratch: all HR policies, ethics and transparency standards, and operational planning
- Talent Acquisition & Employer Branding — worldwide recruitment and selection, employer branding and talent acquisition policies, internship protocols, and external partnerships
- Employee Experience & Lifecycle — onboarding and offboarding, structured 30/60/90/120-day check-ins, satisfaction surveys, integration and expectations management
- Performance & Career Management — performance evaluation framework (9-box and 360°), job grading, salary levels, career progression and variable pay calculation
- Total Rewards — compensation, benefits and incentives, payroll, and salary benchmarking
- Culture, Engagement & Wellbeing — company culture, engagement, organizational commitment, recognition and wellbeing policies
- Learning & Development — training plans, internal training and assessment design
- Workforce models & restructuring — contractors, service providers and outsourcing; restructuring, negotiation, requalification and outplacement
- AI-first HR & distributed teams — integrating artificial intelligence into HR processes while managing remote teams across a multicultural, geographically dispersed organization

ALMA Development | Panhard International

Human Resources & Operations Manager

June 2024 - June 2025 (1 year 1 month)

Lisbon, Portugal

Human Resources and Finance management for a group of 8 companies under Panhard International (Luxembourg), operating across Portugal and

Luxembourg. Primary liaison between the company, shareholders, and investors.

- HR Operations & employee lifecycle — full ownership of the employee lifecycle: personnel administration, hiring and onboarding, and contract management
- Payroll, Total Rewards & Performance Management — payroll processing, salary reviews, compensation & benefits, variable pay (commissions and productivity bonuses), and performance evaluation
- Talent Acquisition — end-to-end recruitment and selection, onboarding and offboarding
- Labour compliance — liaison with employment law partners and continuous alignment of practices with current legislation
- Employee Engagement — design and organization of teambuilding initiatives
- Finance management — full ownership of the finance function (until the integration of a CFO): banking management, payments, budget control, document classification, and financial reporting to C-level
- Digital transformation / AI — led an AI project to develop a custom application for automated document classification and management

Ad Insert Tech

Human Resources & Operations Manager

August 2018 - May 2024 (5 years 10 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

Built the Lisbon hub from the ground up for a Swiss-based ad insertion platform (HQ in Lausanne), creating and leading the full HR function at a strategic, director level, alongside Finance. A startup in Portugal — and a global scale-up — fast-paced and technically demanding, with geographically, culturally and linguistically diverse teams across Portugal and Switzerland.

- Strategic HR leadership — designed and led the entire HR function from scratch, with director-level responsibility for the Portuguese operation
- HR policies & frameworks — recruitment & selection and career development policies, job grading and leveling framework, salary bands and annual salary reviews
- Technical Talent Acquisition — high-volume recruitment and selection of engineering and technical profiles, hiring, and IEFPP internship contracts
- Learning & Development — annual training plans and professional certification programs, critical in a highly technical environment

- Performance & Talent Management — performance evaluation and management of distributed teams across Portugal and Switzerland
- Compensation & Benefits — design and management of compensation and benefits structures
- Employee lifecycle & stakeholder management — onboarding/offboarding, payroll, outsourcing management, and local representation of the leadership to the engineering team
- Finance — treasury, analytical accounting and cost centers, budgeting, and procurement

NEYA Hotels

Office Manager

October 2017 - August 2018 (11 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

Office Management for the AZAD / Grupo NEYA group. Key responsibilities in executive advisory and procurement — leading the procurement process for the "NEYA Porto Hotel" project, coordinating with architecture and interior design firms, contract negotiation, and event planning.

Orbest

Office Manager

January 2017 - October 2017 (10 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

Office Management for Orbest and Evelop Airlines (Grupo Barceló, Spain). Primary point of contact with INAC — the Portuguese National Civil Aviation Authority. C-level advisory in a commercial aviation environment.

Flow Options

Human Resources & Operations Manager

January 2011 - March 2016 (5 years 3 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

A software house created as a spin-off from the CSO group, built from the ground up — focused on innovation and development projects, including QREN and European funding applications — with a significant workforce placed in outsourcing at large clients.

As in my earlier startup experience, I owned the HR function end-to-end while also coordinating Finance and Project Management:

- Talent Acquisition & employee lifecycle — recruitment and selection, contracting, onboarding, payroll, salary reviews and job grading, and offboarding, for internal teams and outsourcing placements
- Learning & Development — training and development plans
- Stakeholder management — direct interface with the partner and shareholder group
- Project management — QREN and EU-funded innovation projects, including resource management
- Workforce restructuring — guided the company through its full organizational lifecycle, including a final restructuring phase: downsizing, mutual agreements, and partnership renegotiations.
- Finance — treasury, budgeting, cost control, accounting liaison, invoicing, collections, and supplier and partnership contracts

ANAC - Autoridade Nacional da Aviação Civil

Office Manager

February 2010 - January 2011 (1 year)

Lisbon, Portugal

Direct report and trusted advisor to the Director of Operational Safety, providing personal advisory and executive secretariat. Coordination of EASA (European Aviation Safety Agency) and ICAO (International Civil Aviation Organization) audits. Liaison with government entities and media relations on behalf of the Directorate. A deeply motivating experience within the aviation world.

Cartório Notarial MCG

Office Manager

April 2009 - February 2010 (11 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

Transitional period focused on refining work methodologies, registry processes, document management, and administrative procedures in a notarial environment.

Glintt

Human Resources Director

November 1997 - March 2009 (11 years 5 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

12 years within the same technology organization through continuous M&A transformation: I joined Infomania (a 20-25 person startup), acquired by SoIS — which, after integrating 12+ tech companies, grew beyond 300 people and,

within the Mota-Engil Group, underwent a major restructuring down to ~80 people — followed by the sale to Pararede and final integration into Glinnt (ANF Group).

Cross-cutting exposure to every company stage — startup in ramp-up, scale-up, SME, large company and multinational context — leading HR with a team of 5. At Infomania, the founding role also included full coordination of Finance — budgeting, accounting liaison, invoicing, collections, and supplier and partnership contracts.

- Built the HR function from scratch — all core HR processes, policies, and governance frameworks across multiple entities
- Led HR strategy during M&A cycles — cultural integration, organizational redesign, and harmonization across 12+ companies
- Talent Acquisition (national & international) — end-to-end recruitment across permanent, temporary, freelance, and outsourcing models
- Performance & Talent Management — performance evaluation systems (360° and 9-box), career paths, and succession planning
- Compensation & Benefits — salary structures, job grading, variable compensation, commissions, and incentives
- Learning & Development — internal academy, training plans, certification and internship programs
- Workforce restructuring — downsizing, mutual agreements, renegotiations, and outplacement
- Employee lifecycle — onboarding, integration, engagement, and offboarding frameworks
- Culture & Change Management — aligning diverse organizational cultures following multiple mergers
- Stakeholder management — direct reporting to Board and collaboration with Group HR shared services (Mota-Engil / MESP)

Time To Train

Managing Partner - Entrepreneurship

January 1999 - December 2001 (3 years)

Lisbon, Portugal

Co-founded and managed a training company end-to-end as Managing Partner. Authored the business plan alongside a co-founding partner, with financial investment from a third shareholder.

Full 360° management: training programme design and delivery (CCP certified trainer), HR, Finance, Office, leasing negotiation, INOFOR

accreditation, European funding acquisition, business development, partnership management, and brand identity creation from scratch.

Markfel / TB Conseil

Human Resources & Operations Manager

February 1996 - November 1997 (1 year 10 months)

Lisbon, Portugal

Lisbon hub of Markfel, part of TB Conseil Group (France) — a professional publishing house operating across Portugal, Spain and France.

- HR from scratch — built the HR function as the sole HR lead in Portugal (first HR role), within an international, multicultural setting
- Talent Acquisition & onboarding — end-to-end recruitment, selection and onboarding of a distributed team of in-house staff, freelancers and external collaborators
- Employee lifecycle & cross-border collaboration — full ownership of the employee lifecycle and of day-to-day collaboration between the Lisbon and French teams
- HR–Finance interface — budget, banking and all payments
- Stakeholder management — reported to the Portuguese CEO and to the Group Director in France

Education

Universidade Europeia

Pós-graduação Lato Sensu, Gestão de Pessoas, Equipas e Trabalho Remoto · (2022 - 2023)

Universidade Europeia

Licenciatura pré-Bolonha, Assessoria de Administração · (1995 - 1997)

Universidade Europeia

Bacharelato pré-Bolonha, Secretariado de Direcção · (1992 - 1995)